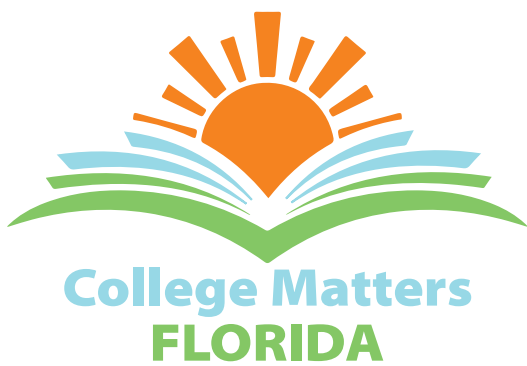




PROMISING PRACTICES

NUMBER 4

Expanding Disability Services with Peer Mentor Support: Strategies and Recommendations from THRIVE at the University of North Florida

Program Background

For incoming students, the adjustment to college can include feelings of enthusiasm and trepidation about navigating new activities and expectations. Peer mentors can help students adjust to new academic and independent living responsibilities. They can also help peers learn to navigate the campus community, as well as its activities and resources.

In 2011, staff from the University of North Florida's Student Accessibility Services (SAS) noticed a pattern of students and parents contacting their office seeking support for non-academic issues, such as residential life and roommate conflicts. Though these issues were beyond SAS's scope of responsibility, staff understood that no other campus resources were adequately addressing non-academic issues. Dr. Tara Rowe was an undergraduate student working in the SAS office as an educational assistant at this time. She became part of a small team that researched what other universities and colleges were doing to support students' non-academic challenges. The team learned about programs that had success with peer mentoring services. These services provided students the additional support to improve their chances of college success. The SAS team established their own peer mentoring services for their THRIVE program, which supports students with autism. Dr. Rowe, now the associate director of SAS and director of the THRIVE program, oversees the peer mentoring services, including mentor training, curriculum development and certification.

Implementation

To establish the peer mentoring component, the THRIVE staff began with a pilot of six volunteer mentors. Based on the literature and their own experiences, they determined students often needed support in one of three general areas: social skills, independent living skills, and career development skills. In 2015, when Dr. Rowe lead the THRIVE program alone, she identified a fourth area of need: executive function skills. In initial meetings with students who applied for a mentor, THRIVE staff and students worked together to determine the types of support each student needed. This allowed students targeted support and the opportunity to make decisions and choices.

THRIVE staff believed targeted training was necessary to ensure peer mentors understood how to support a mentee with autism, specifically within the four program areas of focus. Dr. Rowe tapped into an existing online training series offered by the College Reading and Learning Association (CRLA) called Peer Educator Training. Dr. Rowe also completed several other life coaching certificate programs to create a unique training program specific to the THRIVE program.

The CRLA training results in a peer mentor certification. All THRIVE mentors are required to complete the Level 1 certification during the first semester of mentoring. Topics include:

- the role of the peer educator
- peer educator do's and don'ts
- professional ethics for peer educators
- establishing rapport and motivating students



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After completing Level 1, THRIVE mentors are eligible to participate and complete Level 2 mentor training, which includes additional training topics such as:

- conflict resolution
- mentoring boundaries
- leadership styles
- academic program exploration

To participate in the THRIVE program and receive peer mentoring, eligible students must first be admitted to the university. Following admission, students must be registered with the SAS office. After registering with the SAS office, they may choose to apply for THRIVE supports, which includes peer mentoring. Students meet with THRIVE staff to establish goals. Students have access to Dr. Rowe's weekly online class about various topics of executive functioning. Dr. Rowe developed all course content and material to the specific needs of college students with disabilities. THRIVE also provides weekly individual and peer mentor meetings to students for the first year of college. In time, the goal is to fade support, but also be available to help students tap into campus resources independently.

Peer mentors are eligible for financial compensation through various funding sources, including Federal Work Study, internships/practicums, and private gifts and donations from THRIVE families. All THRIVE services are free for students. THRIVE has also received occasional mini-grants and work-study opportunities to help pay peer mentors for their work. All THRIVE peer mentors earn a Level 1 and 2 peer education certification as a result of completing the THRIVE mentor training.

Impact

THRIVE's peer mentoring services have benefited students with autism in a number of ways. Most significantly, students have more inclusive experiences as a result of peer mentor supports. Because the THRIVE peer mentoring model is based on individualized support and planning, students with autism receive specific peer mentor supports that help them achieve personal, social, and academic goals and develop and practice executive function skills. Mentees are more likely to have better residential living success and to participate more in student life activities. For example, students develop problem-solving strategies, obtain internships with the university's athletic teams, and develop connections to peers outside of classes. Additionally, students and parents have reported mentoring has made a positive difference in the quality of their college experience.

Interest in THRIVE's peer mentoring services has grown considerably since its initiation in 2011. The program now supports 135 students with nine trained mentors. Dr. Rowe shared that a challenge they now face is how to maintain the quality of the peer mentoring supports as student interest grows. Their goal is to make sure they sustain all elements of the services, which remain cost-free and voluntary.

Suggestions for Replication

- Be clear when advertising for peer mentors that you are looking for a full academic year commitment. Both peer mentors and mentees benefit from a 2-semester partnership.
- Develop a job description and training schedule for peer mentors. Consider using an established peer education training curriculum, such as the College Reading and Learning Association's Peer Education Training Program. Make sure to tailor the training curriculum to the specific program needs.
- Be familiar with all the potential campus resources for students (e.g., tutoring and academic supports, disability services, counseling, health and wellness services, residential assistant support) and include these in student and peer mentor advising.
- Design individualized student-mentor plans for each student rather than offering generic peer support.
- Meet regularly with students and peer mentors to review goals and progress. Administrative support must be fully engaged in overseeing program activities. Dr. Rowe reviews weekly mentor session notes and works with THRIVE staff to identify areas of concern and to highlight effective practices.

- Be aware of all potential resources, including course credit, internships, and work-study opportunities that peer mentors might be eligible to apply to their mentoring work.

Additional Resources

For more resources on starting your own peer mentoring services:

- Think College offers a number of downloadable peer mentoring resources through their [Think College Resource Library](#)
- [International Peer Educator Training Program Certification, College Reading and Learning Association](#)

**For more information on THRIVE's Peer
Mentoring services:**

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